minded'. However, he alerted Vijayaraghavachari to two difficulties. 'One is that timid loyalists may not have to do anything with a project which, at one time, was sought to be associated with, most atrociously no doubt, a seditious movement. The other is that several companies have been started in Bengal & people here will naturally prefer them over companies to that of another province.' But if Vijayaraghavachari's agents were 'clever men', he said, 'it is bound to be attended with success'. Towards this end, Motilal Ghose asked him to '[p]repare a statement showing clearly that the project has every prospect of success & ought to be supported by all Swadeshis'.[48] Vijayaraghavachari is sure to have prepared the said statement, but his men, clever or not, did not seem to have met with any success.

In this context, in June 1909 or thereabouts, SSNCo's Calcutta branch office was either opened again or was shifted to the third storey of No. 14, Clive Street on a monthly rent of Rs 35.[49] Mandayam S. Parthasarathy manned it as Agent but with only a peon to assist him.[50] He himself lived on 47, Ezra Street, a short walk from the branch office.[51] This probably coincided with the Mandayam family's heavy investment in the company. The primary function of the branch was to sell shares, and Parthasarathy succeeded in selling forty shares each to the raja of Narajole and Raja Surjya Nath Ray of Faridpur, and a few others in Eastern Bengal and Assam. Surendranath Banerjea, the doyen of Bengal nationalists, declined the director-ship of SSNCo, even though he generously gave letters of introduction to many gentlemen.[52] Managing the Calcutta branch apart, Parthasarathy also came forward to travel in north India to mobilize share capital.[53] The Bengal Police report stated that Parthasarathy 'mixes with all the swadeshi agitators of Calcutta'.[54]



How were these efforts to raise fresh capital and resume the steamer services seen by the patriotically inclined public?

One 'Galle-nesan' ('a friend of Galle'), writing in *Swadesamitran*, said he had been to Colombo (from Galle) on 13 April 1909, to make inquiries